

HASHKAMA WEEKLY

פרשת צו
י' ניסן תשפ"ו
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חכמה ב-א תאמין?

By Reb Gemini

Consider the following "Torah" thought, generated by Gemini: Did the AI get it right? Do you find it to be accurate? Or did the technology miss the boat?

In this week's parsha, Tzav, the Torah commands us regarding the Korban Olah (Burnt Offering), stating, "Aish tamid tukad al hamizbeach lo tichbeh"—a constant fire shall burn upon the altar; it shall not be extinguished (Vayikra 6:6). The Sefer HaChinuch (Mitzvah 132) explains that the continuous physical fire mirrors the constant spiritual fire we must maintain in our hearts. Naturally, maintaining a constant fire is no small feat, much to the chagrin of our esteemed Shul President, who I am certain is having palpitations right now just thinking about the gas bill for an eternal flame. But the aish tamid teaches us that inspiration cannot be a sporadic event, only showing up for Neilah or when the cholent is particularly good. It must be a low, steady burn—a consistent, daily commitment to Torah and mitzvos that does not waver based on our fluctuating moods or the draftiness of the sanctuary. This steady baseline of spiritual warmth directly fuels the second crucial lesson found later in the parsha regarding the Korban Todah, the Thanksgiving Offering. The Torah dictates that the Todah and its accompanying forty loaves of bread must be entirely consumed by morning (Vayikra 7:15). The Abarbanel (on Vayikra 7) brilliantly points out that forcing a person to eat forty loaves of bread in a single day practically guarantees they will have to invite friends, family, and perhaps the entire mizrach wall to help finish the feast, thereby publicizing the miracle Hashem performed for them. Without the aish tamid—that constant, burning awareness of Hakadosh Baruch Hu in our daily routine—we could easily mistake our successes for our own brilliance and completely overlook the miracles that require a Todah in the first place. It is precisely our everyday spiritual fire that illuminates our blessings, prompting us to gather our community and express gratitude, even if it means carbo-loading to an extent that would make the Gabbai extremely nervous about the resulting crumbs on the new sanctuary carpet.

Practical Takeaway: This week, focus on tending to your personal aish tamid by committing to one small, unglamorous daily habit, such as reciting Asher Yatzar with profound concentration or arriving at Shacharis before the first Kaddish. By keeping that steady fire burning, you will condition yourself to recognize the daily, hidden miracles in your life, transforming routine existence into a constant state of Todah—and saving us all from having to somehow eat forty loaves of bread by ourselves.

News & Simchos!

All Previous Newsletters are available to download at: archive.bm715.vip

No Kiddush This Week
The Shul is Cleaned for Pesach

Attention Gentlemen
Friday Mincha: 2:30 PM

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Shabbus Zmanim

Chestnut Ridge, NY

2:30 pm	מנחה
5:28/6:58 pm	הדלקה (Early/Late)
--- pm	מנחה - קבלת שבת
7:16 pm	שקיעה
5:23/5:34 am	עלות השחר (16.1/72)
6:46:00 am	נץ החמה
7:15 am	שחרית
Hot kiddush & Shiur after davening	
9:18/9:54 am	סיור קריאת שמע
10:32/10:56 am	סיור תפילה
1:01:07 pm	חצות היום
1:32:47 pm	מנחה גדולה (30)
4:40:32 pm	מנחה קטנה (גר"א)
5:58:45 pm	פלג המנחה (גר"א)
--- pm	מנחה
7:17 pm	שקיעה
7:58/8:07 pm	צה"כ ר' משה (8.5/50)
8:09 pm	מעריב (52)
8:17/8:29 pm	צה"כ (60/72)



In Two Week's Zmanim

Chestnut Ridge, NY

2:30 pm	מנחה
6:09/7:13 pm	הדלקה (Early/Late)
7:31 pm	שקיעה
7:15 am	שחרית
7:32 pm	שקיעה
8:41 pm	מעריב (52)

This Week's Riddle

Riddle: Where does the word for "ash" (deshen) appear in the Torah (5 times)?

Answer: Deshen appears twice in this parsha (Vayikra 6:3-4) and three times in parshas Vayikra (Vayikra 1:16, 4:12).



Donations & Payments

Zelle: Send to 845-252-1260

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Gift Card/Bitcoin: Do we look like Indian Scammers to you?

שבת הגדול דרשה ב-א תאמין?

By Reb Gemini

Read at your own risk!

Section 1 The Foundation of the Bayis: As we prepare for Shabbos Hagadol, the collective anxiety regarding Pesach cleaning inevitably reaches a fever pitch. We scour our kitchens with toothbrushes and examine our baseboards as if we are auditing the Federal Reserve. Yet, the Gemara in Sotah (17a) teaches us a fundamental principle: Ish ve'isha zachu, Shechinah beineihem—if a husband and wife are meritorious, the Divine Presence dwells among them. The truest foundation of our home, our Mikdash Me'at (miniature sanctuary), is not the absence of breadcrumbs behind the refrigerator, but the presence of shalom bayis (marital harmony). In our generation, we are exceptionally skilled at over-engineering our physical homes while neglecting our spiritual ones. It is entirely possible, and frankly common, to have a congregant who can effortlessly configure a home server running Unraid or Home Assistant to automatically dim the dining room lights on a schedule, yet the basic communication protocol between husband and wife is somehow returning a constant 404 Error. Chametz is the ultimate symbol of a bloated ego. When we bring our inflated pride into our marriages—insisting on having the last word or holding onto minor grievances—we are effectively hoarding spiritual chametz. We must realize that the most rigorous bedikas chametz (search for leaven) required of us is sweeping the resentment out of our own marriages.

Section 2 The Transmission of the Mesorah: This foundational shalom bayis is not merely a private matter between spouses; it is the absolute prerequisite for effective chinuch (child-rearing). The entire framework of the Pesach Seder is built upon the pasuk, Vehigadeta levincha—and you shall tell your son (Shemos 13:8). But how exactly do we tell them? The Sefer HaChinuch (Mitzvah 16) famously posits that acharei hapeulos nimshechim halevavos—the heart is drawn after one's actions. Children are the ultimate spiritual lie detectors. You can deliver the most eloquent, scholarly divrei Torah at the Seder table, but if your children witness constant bickering, sarcasm, or a glaring lack of mutual respect between their parents the rest of the year, your holy words will land with the profound, heavy thud of a dropped kneidlach. We often spend our daily commutes driving from our homes to our offices in Spring Valley, utilizing that quiet time in the car to catch up on business calls or listen to the radio, while severely neglecting the essential, daily check-ins with our own children. True chinuch is transmitted through the atmosphere of the home. If the atmosphere is thick with tension and inflated egos, the children will absorb the tension, not the Torah.

Section 3 The Empty Air of Machlokes: This brings us to the profound conceptual difference between chametz and matzah as it relates to our family dynamics. The Kli Yakar (Shemos 12:15) explains that chametz represents the yetzer hara (evil inclination), which by its very nature causes division, separation, and machlokes (dispute). Why does dough rise? It rises because trapped air creates pockets of emptiness that literally push the ingredients apart from the inside out. Matzah, conversely, is flat, dense, and unified. It represents the humility required to stay close together. In our community, it is sometimes much easier to write a generous check to buy the shul a new heavy-duty safe or a set of tables than it is to secure the spiritual safety of our own dining rooms. The Seder night demands that we return to the state of matzah. It asks us to deflate our egos, to sit together in tight quarters without letting the empty air of pride push us apart. Only when a home is unified in the humility of matzah can it become a place where the next generation feels comfortable enough to ask the Mah Nishtanah and actually care about the answer.

Practical Takeaway: This Pesach, your practical assignment is to perform a spiritual mechiras chametz (selling of the leaven) on your overwhelming need to be right. When a disagreement arises with your spouse regarding the holiday preparations, or when your child tests your patience precisely five minutes before Yom Tov, choose the flatness of matzah over the rising dough of your own anger. Voluntarily give up the need for the last word. By doing so, you will guarantee that the most beautiful, pristine thing sitting at your Seder table is not the imported Shmura Matzah, but the impenetrable shalom within your family.

GOOD SHABBUS!